

Strain, not salary: what actually keeps Dutch teachers in the classroom

An analysis of which working conditions are statistically associated with a teacher considering leaving the profession.

AUTHOR

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INTENDED AUDIENCE

School boards · VO-raad · Ministry of Education (OCW)

FULL ANALYSIS & CODE

[README.md](#) · [analysis.py](#)

IN BRIEF

Dutch teacher-retention policy has, since 2023, relied primarily on **pay increases and structural reform**. This brief presents a narrower and more actionable analysis of OECD TALIS 2024 data on 2,576 Dutch lower-secondary teachers, examining which of the working conditions schools can realistically change are statistically associated with a teacher considering leaving the profession.

The findings do not support the dominant policy narrative. Psychological strain and a perceived lack of recognition, rather than salary, autonomy, or school leadership, are the factors most strongly associated with teachers considering leaving the profession.

The proportion of teachers considering leaving rises from **8% to 50%** as self-reported work stress increases from "not at all" to "a lot."

The apparent mid-career risk increase (11–20 years) is a **descriptive pattern only**; years of experience is not a statistically significant predictor once strain is held constant (OR 1.06, 95% CI 0.87–1.29).

Once strain and recognition are accounted for, **salary satisfaction, classroom autonomy, and supportive leadership** show no significant association with considering leaving.

The 2025 decrease in the reported shortage (5.1% → 3.5%) is a **temporary, demand-side effect** and should not be read as evidence that retention has improved. Official projections indicate the secondary shortage will increase again toward 2029 (CentERdata/OCW, 2024).

These findings indicate that the policy instruments currently in most active use — pay increases and structural reorganisation — are not the instruments this evidence associates with retaining teachers. Workload and recognition are the more relevant levers.

Why this matters now

Public and policy debate on the *lerarentekort* (teacher shortage) has largely settled on two diagnoses: that teachers are underpaid, and that the system requires restructuring. Since 2023, primary-school salaries have risen by approximately 10% and the historic primary–secondary pay gap has closed (CNV, 2023); the

government has introduced regional *Onderwijsregio's* and a national programme to strengthen the profession (Rijksoverheid, 2024).

Between 2024 and 2025, the secondary-education shortage fell from 5.1% to 3.5% (VO-raad, 2025). The sector body and the ministry state explicitly that this is

a temporary, demand-driven decrease — attributable to falling pupil numbers and the end of pandemic-era (NPO) funding — rather than an indication that retention has improved. Teacher unemployment-benefit (WW) claims rose in 2025 for the first time since 2019 (AOB, 2025), indicating that qualified teachers are leaving employment even as the shortage persists.

Approximately two-thirds of the remaining shortage is now "hidden," absorbed as increased workload and rising burnout among teachers who remain in post (VO-raad, 2025), and is concentrated in the *tekortvakken*

(mathematics, physics, chemistry, computer science, languages) and the largest cities (VO-raad, 2025; Voion/OCW, 2025). Official forecasts indicate the secondary shortage will increase again, to approximately 2,900 FTE by 2029 and 3,500 FTE by 2034 (CentERdata/OCW, 2024).

In summary, the interventions that have received the greatest political and financial investment have not resolved the underlying problem. This brief examines whether the available evidence points toward alternative policy levers.

Research question

Of the working conditions that schools and policymakers can directly influence, which are predictive of a teacher considering leaving the profession? The analysis statistically distinguishes between **modifiable working conditions** (stress, mental-health strain, recognition, workload, autonomy, pay, leadership, classroom disruption) and **fixed background characteristics** (age, experience, and whether teaching was a first-choice career), using TALIS 2024 data on Dutch teachers (OECD, 2024).

What the evidence shows

Among the 2,576 Dutch lower-secondary teachers surveyed, **22%** agree they "wonder whether it would be better to choose another profession."

1. The likelihood of considering leaving increases substantially with strain

Considering leaving, by self-reported work stress	
SELF-REPORTED WORK STRESS	CONSIDERING LEAVING
Not at all	8%
To some extent	14%
Quite a bit	28%
A lot	50%

In the adjusted model, *"my job harms my mental health"* and *work stress* are the strongest predictors overall, each raising the odds of considering leaving by approximately 50–65% per one-standard-deviation increase, holding all other factors constant.

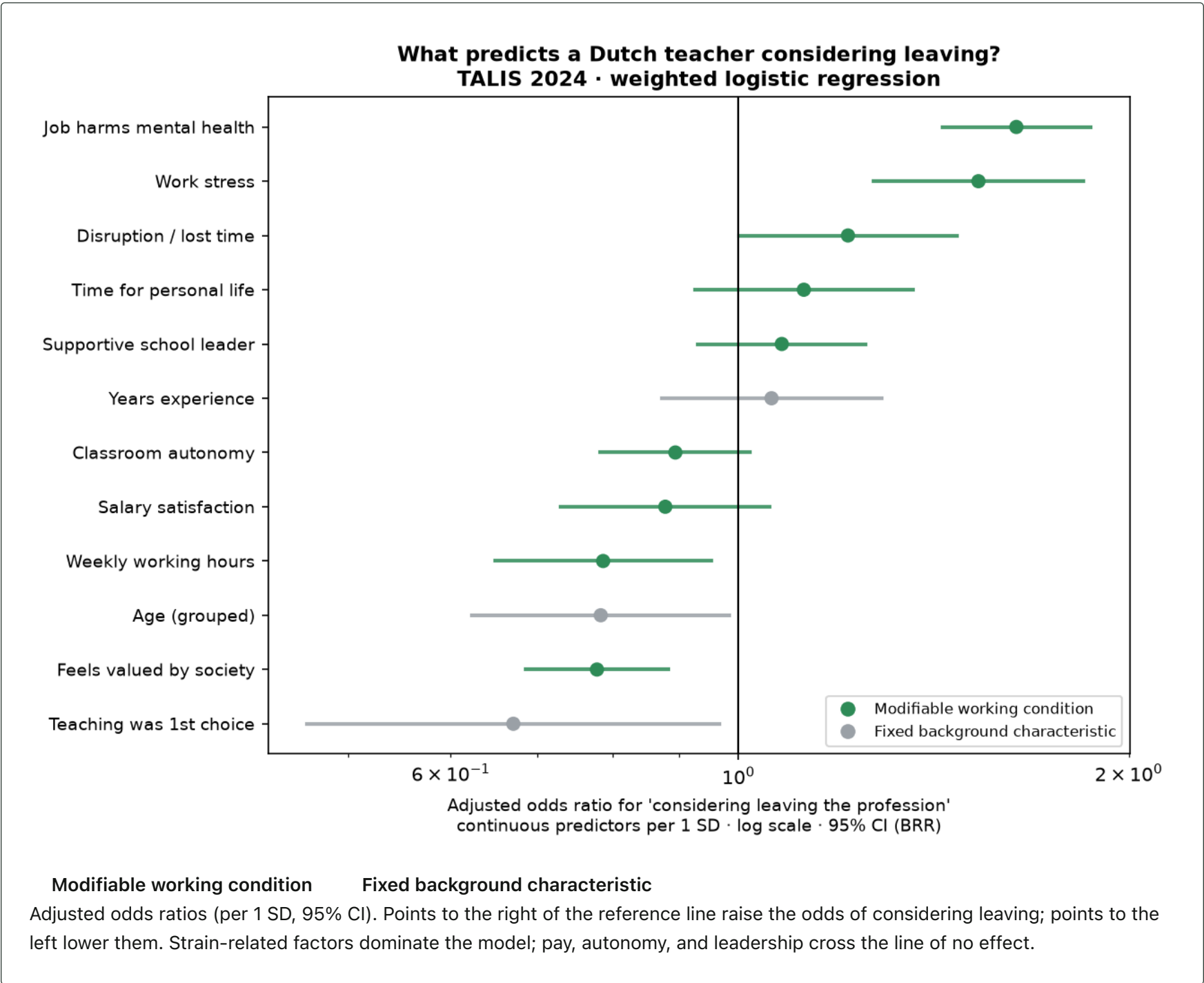
2. Risk increases through mid-career and declines among veteran teachers, though this pattern is descriptive rather than statistically confirmed

Considering leaving, by years of experience	
YEARS OF EXPERIENCE	CONSIDERING LEAVING
≤5 yrs	20%
6–10 yrs	23%
11–20 yrs	26%
20+ yrs	17%

Once strain is accounted for, years of experience is not a statistically significant predictor (OR 1.06, 95% CI 0.87–1.29). The mid-career increase should be interpreted as an indication for further investigation rather than as a robust, independent effect.

3. Recognition is associated with retention; salary, autonomy, and leadership are not, once strain is controlled for

Teachers who feel valued by society are significantly less likely to consider leaving. Salary satisfaction, classroom autonomy, and supportive school leadership show no significant association with considering leaving once strain and recognition are included in the model.



Implications for practice

The recommendations below are drawn from the Onderwijsraad and recent peer-reviewed research, and are consistent with the findings of this analysis. They are organised according to which actor is best positioned to act on them.

FOR SCHOOL BOARDS & LEADERS

- **Reduce workload by protecting teachers' core task.** The Onderwijsraad's advisory report *Schaarste schuurt* argues that the shortage cannot be resolved in the short term without decisive curriculum choices and reorganised school work, so that teaching staff can concentrate on teaching while other roles absorb supporting tasks (Onderwijsraad, 2023).
- **Prioritise job enrichment alongside pay.** A two-wave study of 637 Dutch teachers found that job enrichment increased satisfaction and engagement and lowered intention to leave, without increasing burnout when well managed (Erasmus University Rotterdam, 2025).
- **Treat strain and workload as a governed, measured retention risk,** rather than a background condition managed on an informal basis.

FOR VO-RAAD & NATIONAL POLICY (OCW)

- **Establish retention as a shared, funded responsibility.** The Onderwijsraad assigns leadership and vision to administrators, school leaders, and the state, and calls for adequate, structural funding with additional support for vulnerable schools (Onderwijsraad, 2023).
- **Recalibrate the policy narrative.** The post-2023 pay increases did not prevent shortages that are projected to rise again toward 2029 (CentERdata/OCW, 2024). Continued emphasis on pay risks overlooking the lever this evidence identifies as most relevant.
- **Invest more broadly in the status and attractiveness of the profession,** as recommended by the Onderwijsraad (Onderwijsraad, 2023).

For future research

The most consistent finding of this analysis — that strain and workload are the strongest predictors of intention to leave — is based on cross-sectional data. Validating this finding with panel data, examining whether teachers reporting high strain leave the profession at higher rates over time, would convert an association into evidence sufficiently robust to justify workload targets at board and ministry level.

How robust is this?

- **Data and method.** OECD TALIS 2024, 2,576 Dutch lower-secondary teachers (OECD, 2024). Survey-weighted logistic regression using TALIS's final teacher weight, with design-correct (balanced-repeated-replication) confidence intervals.
- **Confirmed using two approaches.** An ordinal model on the full four-point response scale, and a separate outcome variable — the number of years a teacher intends to continue teaching — both reproduce the main result.
- **Key limitations.** The survey is cross-sectional and self-reported, so the results reported here are associations rather than established causes. The item *"my job harms my mental health"* is conceptually close to the outcome and may lie on the causal pathway to leaving rather than functioning as an independent predictor. The job-design measures (pay, autonomy, leadership) were administered to smaller sub-samples, so a null result may reflect limited statistical power as well as a genuine absence of effect.

I deliberately grounded the recommendations above in established expert bodies rather than my own judgement. My initial reading of the TALIS 2024 data pointed to a continuing shortage; only through further iteration did I identify the 2025 decrease, and subsequently learn that it is widely interpreted as temporary and demand-driven rather than as a genuine improvement. Methodologically, I separated modifiable from fixed conditions because only the former can inform policy, used TALIS's replicate weights so that the reported uncertainty reflects the survey's complex design, and verified the headline result against a second outcome variable. What I found most notable was how little pay, autonomy, and leadership mattered once strain and recognition were included in the model.

— AUTHOR'S NOTE

Transparency and use of AI. The analysis, modelling choices, and conclusions presented in this brief are my own. AI tools were used as an assistant for code review; all statistical results were produced by the reproducible code in [analysis.py](#), and every source was checked against the original publication (verified June 2026).

SOURCES

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